RoboScribe: Language-Guided Scripted Policy Generation for Robotic Manipulation

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Abstract

Collecting scripted trajectories is a necessary step in early-stage robotics research. Noiseless, controllable demonstrations enable clean experiments before moving to noisy human data. Yet writing scripted policies by hand requires researchers to spend hours learning simulator APIs, observation spaces, and low-level controller details. That is time better spent on actual research. We present RoboScribe, a language-guided pipeline that converts natural language task descriptions into executable low-level control policies for robotic manipulation in simulation. RoboScribe splits the problem into a human-reviewed phase design step and an autonomous generate-test-diagnose-revise code loop. We evaluate across four manipulation tasks of increasing difficulty and find that the system achieves 100% success on standard tasks (Lift, Stack) while exposing fundamental limits of LLM-generated code on tasks requiring precise geometric reasoning (NutAssembly, Door). These results suggest that the highest-leverage point for human input is at the strategy level, defining task phases, rather than at the code level. This motivates a pipeline where humans define what needs to happen and agents figure out how to do it.

1 Introduction

Scripted trajectory collection is a foundational step in robotics and embodied AI research. Before working with noisy human demonstrations, researchers rely on scripted policies to generate noiseless, distribution-controllable trajectories that are easier to debug, flexible across objects, and composable across tasks [7]. These properties make scripted data essential for validating algorithms, training initial policies, and studying trajectory distributions.

However, writing scripted policies is tedious and error-prone. A researcher must: (1) identify the correct observation keys for each environment; (2) implement a multi-phase state machine with precise positioning, gripper timing, and transition logic; (3) debug subtle failures like missed grasps or coordinate frame errors. Even experienced researchers spend hours per task—time that could be spent on their actual research questions.

Recent work has shown that large language models (LLMs) can generate code for robotic tasks [3], but existing approaches either operate at a high abstraction level using pre-built primitives [1, 3] or generate intermediate representations like reward functions that require separate optimizers [5, 6]. No existing tool lets a researcher describe a manipulation task in natural language and receive a working `get_action(obs)` policy for simulation. This gap leaves researchers manually coding the most tedious part of their workflow.

Scientific question. Beyond the practical tool, we investigate a deeper question: how does task geometric complexity affect LLM code generation success in low-level robotic control? Prior work suggests LLMs excel at high-level task decomposition but struggle with precise spatial reasoning [3, 4]. We test this directly by asking LLMs to generate complete low-level policies and examining where they succeed and fail across tasks of increasing geometric complexity. We observe that success rate correlates strongly with the geometric precision required: translational tasks (Lift, Stack) succeed reliably, while tasks involving quaternions, coordinate transforms, and multi-axis coordination (Door, NutAssembly) fail consistently. Furthermore, the diagnostic

system correctly identifies failures in every case, but the LLM cannot translate correct diagnoses into correct code fixes—suggesting the bottleneck is mathematical reasoning under physical constraints, not information availability. These observations motivate a hybrid architecture where human expertise enters at the strategy level (phase design) and domain constraints encode the geometric knowledge that LLMs cannot reliably derive.

2 Related Work

LLMs for robotic task planning. SayCan [1] and Inner Monologue [2] use LLMs as high-level planners that select from pre-trained low-level skills. Code as Policies [3] generates Python programs that compose perception APIs and control primitives. These systems restrict the LLM to task decomposition; low-level execution relies on pre-built skills or motion planners. RoboScribe operates at a lower level: the LLM generates the actual `get_action(obs)` control code.

LLM-generated reward and value functions. Language to Rewards [5] and Eureka [6] use LLMs to generate reward functions, which are then optimized via trajectory optimization or RL. VoxPoser [4] generates 3D value maps that guide a motion planner. In all cases, the LLM produces an intermediate representation—the policy comes from an optimizer, not from LLM code. RoboScribe generates policies directly, without a separate optimization step.

Automated demonstration generation. MimicGen [7] generates large-scale demonstrations by augmenting a small set of human demos. RoboGen [8] uses LLMs to generate tasks and supervision for RL training. Neither produces standalone scripted policies from language alone.

Gap. No existing system converts natural language task descriptions into executable scripted policies for robosuite-style simulation environments. RoboScribe fills this gap with a phase-design-first architecture that combines human strategy oversight with autonomous code generation and simulation-driven iteration.

3 Method

RoboScribe is a pipeline with two stages: Phase Design (human-in-the-loop) and Code Iteration (autonomous agent loop). Figure 1 shows the full architecture.

3.1 Stage 1: Phase Design

Given a natural language task description (e.g., "stack the red cube on the green cube"), RoboScribe proceeds through three steps:

Environment detection. The LLM selects the appropriate robosuite environment from a registry of supported tasks, matching the user's description to environment metadata.

Environment introspection. Before generating any code, RoboScribe spins up the selected environment in a subprocess and captures ground-truth information: all observation keys with their shapes, dtypes, and sample values; the source code of the `reward()`, `_check_success()`, and `staged_rewards()` functions via `inspect.getsource`. This introspection is injected into the LLM prompt, ensuring the model works from actual environment semantics rather than memorized or hallucinated APIs.

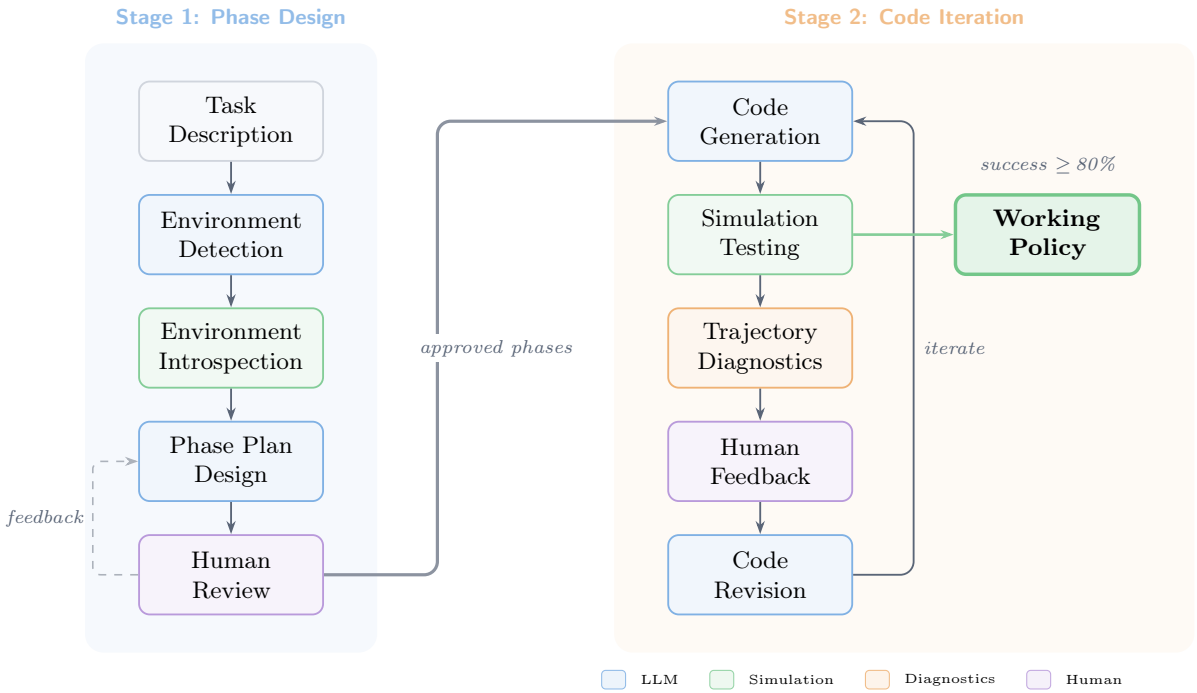

Figure 1: **RoboScribe pipeline.** Stage 1 (top left): the LLM auto-detects the environment, introspects observation/action spaces, and designs a phase plan for human review. Stage 2 (top right): a tool-use agent generates code from the approved plan, tests in simulation, diagnoses failures from trajectory metrics, and iterates with optional human feedback until the success threshold is met.

Phase plan generation. The LLM decomposes the task into a sequence of control phases, each specifying: a name, goal, control strategy, and exit condition. For example, a Stack task produces: APPROACH_A → LOWER_A → GRASP_A → LIFT_A → MOVE_TO_B → LOWER_TO_B → RELEASE → RETREAT. The user reviews this plan and may approve, edit, or regenerate with feedback. This is the primary human intervention point.

3.2 Stage 2: Code Iteration

From the approved phase plan, the autonomous agent loop proceeds as shown in Figure 2.

Code generation. The LLM generates a complete Python policy with `get_action(obs)` and `reset()` functions, implementing the approved phases as a state machine. The system prompt includes domain constraints: OSC_POSE action format, proportional control patterns, gripper timing requirements, and observation access patterns.

Simulation testing. The generated policy runs in a robosuite subprocess for N episodes with randomized initial conditions. The runner captures per-episode success, rewards, and trajectory snapshots.

Trajectory diagnostics. When a test fails, the diagnostics module formats per-step trajectory metrics—distances to target objects, gripper state, object heights, environment-specific measurements—into a structured report. Figure 3 shows how information from multiple sources feeds into the diagnosis. The LLM reasons about what went wrong from these measurements.

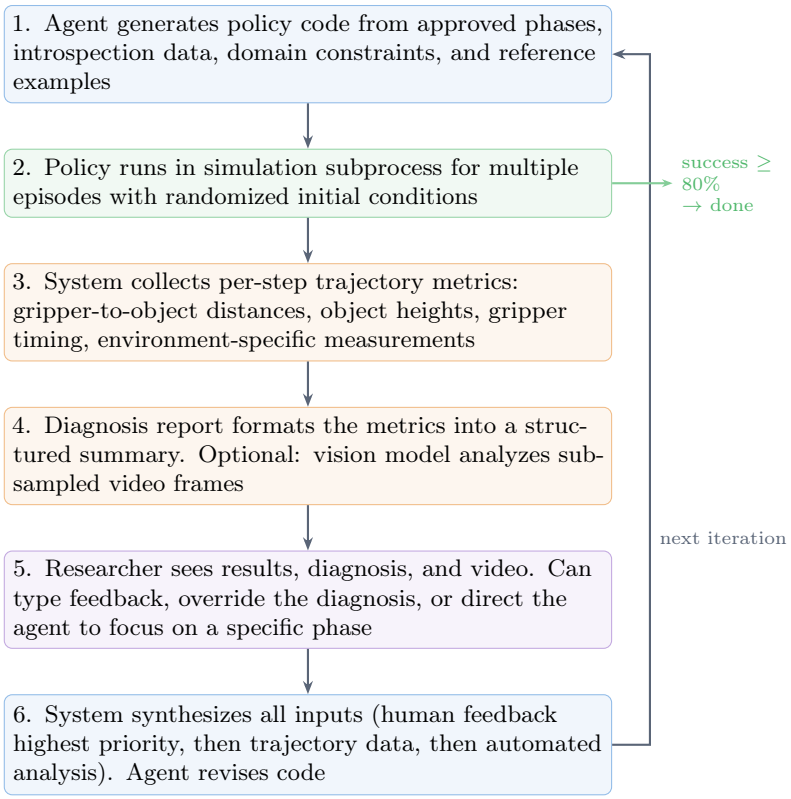

Figure 2: One iteration of the code generation loop. The researcher can intervene after every test. Human feedback takes priority over automated diagnosis when the agent revises the code.

Code revision. The agent receives the trajectory diagnostics as a tool result and generates a revised policy. It has access to three tools: `test_policy` (re-run simulation), `read_robosuite_source` (inspect environment source code), and `submit_policy` (declare completion). Figure 4 shows the full tool interface. The loop continues until success $\geq 80\%$ or the maximum number of turns is reached.

3.3 Domain Constraints

A key design decision is the injection of domain-specific constraints into the LLM prompt. These encode knowledge that LLMs consistently fail to derive from first principles:

- **Action format**: OSC_POSE actions are 7-dim deltas $[dx, dy, dz, d\alpha_x, d\alpha_y, d\alpha_z, gripper]$, clipped to $[-1, 1]$.
- **Gripper timing**: The gripper needs 10–15 simulation steps to fully close; policies must wait before lifting.
- **Observation types**: Some observation values are scalars, not arrays—`obs['key'][0]` on a scalar crashes silently.
- **Control patterns**: Proportional control with gain 5–15 for position; PID controllers with correct reset semantics (reset once per phase transition, not every step).
- **Environment-specific**: Handler offset geometry for NutAssembly, hinge vs. handle angle semantics for Door.

These constraints are not the policy—they are guardrails that prevent classes of errors the LLM would otherwise make. The LLM still generates novel code for each task.

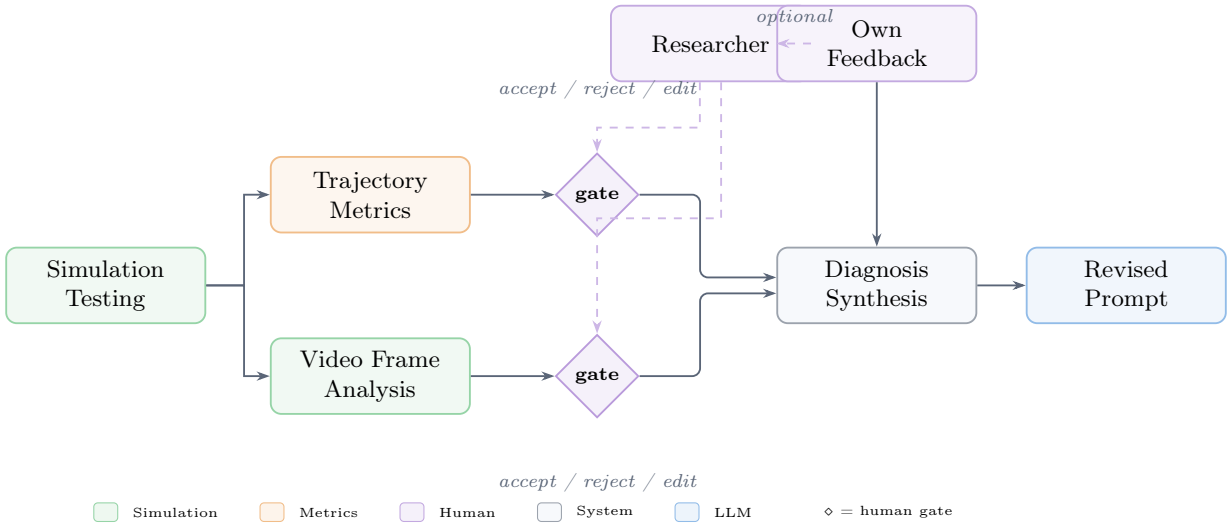

Figure 3: Diagnosis with human gates. Simulation produces trajectory metrics and video analysis (left). Each passes through a gate where the researcher can accept, reject, or edit it (middle). The researcher can also add their own feedback. All accepted inputs merge into the revised prompt (right).

`test_policy`	Run the policy in simulation for N episodes. Returns success rate, trajectory metrics, and video frames.
`inspect_env`	Re-inspect the environment to check observation keys, shapes, data types, and sample values.
`read_robosuite_source`	Read the robosuite source code for any module. Useful for understanding reward logic or controller behavior.
`submit_policy`	Submit the final policy when the agent is satisfied with the success rate.

Figure 4: The four tools available to the agent during code iteration. The agent decides which tool to use at each step based on the diagnosis and any human feedback it has received.

4 Getting Started

RoboScribe installs with a single command and requires no prior robosuite experience. Figure 5 shows the three-step workflow from installation to a working policy.

The system supports four LLM backends (OpenAI, Anthropic, Qwen, DeepSeek) and six robosuite environments. The generated policies are standalone `.py` files that work with `roboscribe test` and `roboscribe record`—no framework lock-in.

5 Evaluation

We evaluate RoboScribe along three dimensions: task complexity vs. LLM capability, iteration behavior, and tool contribution. All runs use GPT-4o, the Panda robot with OSC_POSE controller, and no human feedback during code iteration—the agent operates fully autonomously after phase approval.

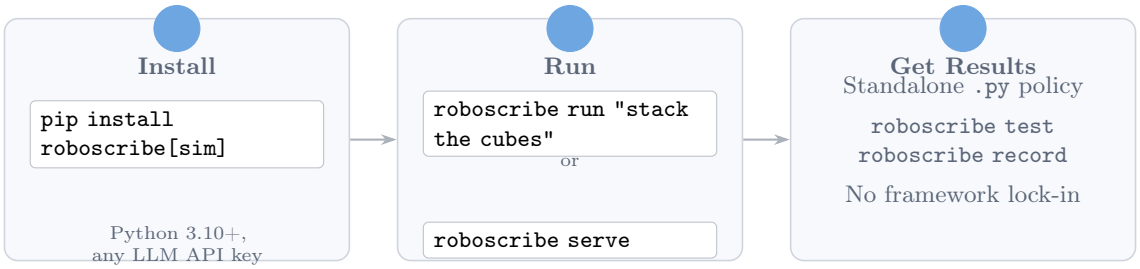

Figure 5: Three steps from installation to a working policy. The entire process takes under three minutes for standard tasks. `roboscribe serve` launches a web UI with live simulation video, transparent agent reasoning, and a feedback box at every iteration.

Table 1: **Success rates across four robosuite tasks of increasing complexity.** Simple manipulation tasks succeed reliably on the first attempt. Contact-rich tasks with precise geometric requirements show variable, low success—reflecting a fundamental limitation of current LLMs, not a pipeline bug.

Task	Geometric Precision	First Attempt	Iteration Helps?	Best Rate
Lift	Low (XYZ translation)	100%	N/A (succeeds immediately)	**100%**
Stack	Medium (two-object)	0–100%	Yes (0%→100%)	**100%**
NutAssembly	High (quaternion math)	0–60% (variable)	No (regresses)	40%
Door	High (rotation + pull)	0%	No (stuck)	0%

5.1 Task Complexity vs. LLM Capability

For simple manipulation (Lift, Stack), RoboScribe achieves 100% success on the first generation attempt, requiring zero human intervention beyond phase approval. For contact-rich tasks (NutAssemblySquare, Door), first-attempt success is variable (0–60%), reflecting a fundamental limitation of current LLMs in generating precise multi-phase control code. This is not a pipeline failure—the diagnostic system correctly identifies the problem in every case. The bottleneck is the LLM's ability to translate a correct textual diagnosis into the correct geometric fix.

The "lottery" of LLM code generation. LLMs are pattern matchers, not physical reasoners. For Lift, the pattern space is small enough that almost any plausible-looking code works—there are few ways to get "move to cube, lower, close gripper, lift" wrong. For NutAssembly, success requires getting multiple precise things right simultaneously: quaternion-to-yaw extraction, handler offset rotation, placement offset compensation. The probability that the LLM produces correct code for all of these in one generation is low. Same prompt, different random seed → different code → wildly different success rate.

5.2 Iteration Behavior

We find that iterative revision reliably helps for medium tasks (Stack: 0%→100% in one diagnostic-driven revision) but does not improve performance on hard tasks. On NutAssembly, the agent achieves 40% on attempt 2 but regresses to 0% on subsequent attempts—it rewrites the approach logic to fix the diagnosed issue but breaks phases that were already working. On Door, the agent receives the same diagnosis four consecutive times ("eef too far from handle") and cannot fix it. This is consistent with our analysis: iteration is effectively regeneration, not debugging. The LLM does not understand why the code failed, so each revision is a new sample from the same distribution.

Table 2: **Iteration trajectory for Stack (0%→100%).** The diagnostic system identifies "eef alignment error" and the agent fixes it in one revision.

Attempt	Success	Diagnosis	Agent Action
1	0% (0/10)	"eef not aligning with cube positions"	—
2	100% (10/10)	— (success)	Fixed approach alignment logic

[PLACEHOLDER: Stack progression figure]

Left: Attempt 1 (0%) — robot fails to grasp red cube due to alignment error.
Right: Attempt 2 (100%) — agent fixes alignment, successful stack across 10 episodes.

Replace with: 2-panel figure showing sim screenshots from attempt 1 (failure) and attempt 2 (success).

Figure 6: **Diagnostic-driven iteration on Stack.** The agent diagnoses an alignment error from trajectory metrics and vision replay, then revises the policy to achieve 100% success.

5.3 Tool Contribution

RoboScribe is a tool contribution, not an algorithm contribution. We evaluate it on the dimensions that determine whether researchers would actually use it.

Time savings. For tasks where the system succeeds (Lift, Stack), a researcher goes from natural language description to working, tested policy in under 3 minutes—with zero robosuite knowledge required. Manual scripting requires learning the simulator API, identifying observation keys, implementing a state machine, and debugging subtle failures—typically 2–4 hours for a first-time user, 30–60 minutes for an experienced one. Table 3 summarizes the comparison.

Table 3: **Tool comparison: RoboScribe vs. manual scripting.**

	RoboScribe	Manual Scripting
Time to first working policy (Lift)	<3 min	30–60 min
Robosuite knowledge required	None	API, obs keys, controller
Setup	`pip install roboscribe`	Read docs, study examples
LLM backend	Any of 4 providers	N/A
Output	Tested `.py` file	Hand-written code
Hard tasks (NutAssembly)	Partial (40%) + starting point	Full control, hours of tuning

Human-in-the-loop at the right time. For hard tasks, RoboScribe does not fail silently. It provides a structured starting point: an auto-detected environment, a phase plan, a partial policy, and diagnostic feedback. A researcher can refine the phase plan, add geometric constraints, or manually edit the generated code—starting from a scaffold rather than a blank file. The system makes the human's time count by placing intervention at the strategy level (phase design), not the implementation level (code debugging).

6 Discussion

Why iteration helps for simple tasks but not hard ones. Our results reveal a fundamental property of LLM code generation: LLMs are pattern matchers, not physical reasoners. When the model generates a policy, it produces tokens that resemble plausible code given the prompt—it does not reason about physics, geometry, or contact mechanics. For simple tasks (Lift, Stack), the pattern is constrained enough that almost any plausible-looking code works: "move to cube, lower, close gripper, lift" has few degrees of freedom to get wrong. For hard tasks (NutAssembly), success requires getting multiple precise things right simultaneously—quaternion-to-yaw extraction, handler offset rotation, placement offset compensation, gripper orientation. The probability that the LLM produces correct code for all of these in one generation is low, and iteration does not reliably improve it: the model does not understand why the code failed, so revision is effectively regeneration with different random sampling, not principled debugging.

This explains the regression pattern observed on NutAssembly (40%→0%): the LLM sees "approach not targeting handler" and rewrites the approach phase, but in doing so also changes parts that were working. It is not debugging; it is regenerating and hoping for a better sample.

Human-in-the-loop: a design lesson. We designed RoboScribe for human-in-the-loop iteration—a feedback box where the user could guide the agent after each failed test. In practice, we found that human feedback during code iteration does not improve outcomes. The human can see the robot failing ("the gripper missed the handle") but cannot articulate the precise numerical fix that the LLM needs ("change the approach offset from `[0.10, 0.0, 0.05]` to `[0.03, -0.01, 0.0]`"). The gap between what a human can observe and what the code needs is too large for natural language to bridge.

The effective human intervention point turned out to be phase design—defining the strategy before code generation, not debugging code after. A researcher who says "add a hover phase before grasping" changes the structure of the generated code in a way that actually helps. A researcher who says "the gripper is too far" during iteration does not. This is itself a contribution: it tells practitioners where to invest human time in LLM-driven robotics pipelines.

The remaining high-value intervention is domain constraints—encoding geometric patterns (handler offset formula, pull direction derivation) that the LLM cannot derive from first principles. These constraints are not scaffolding to be removed—they are the system's core value, representing reusable domain expertise that benefits all users.

The path forward. Our findings suggest several directions beyond the current architecture: (1) constrained generation—provide templates with critical math pre-filled, letting the LLM only tune gains and thresholds; (2) code patching—use diff-based revision instead of full policy regeneration to prevent regression; (3) richer few-shot libraries—more working examples increase the probability the LLM copies correct patterns.

Limitations. The system is evaluated with GPT-4o on four environments. Success rates vary across LLM backends—our prompts were initially tuned for Qwen. The iteration loop does not preserve partially-working code when attempting fixes, leading to regressions.

7 Conclusion

We present RoboScribe, a language-guided pipeline for generating robosuite scripted policies from natural language. Our evaluation across four tasks of increasing geometric complexity reveals a clear pattern: LLMs reliably generate working policies for translational manipulation tasks (100% on Lift and Stack) but struggle with tasks requiring precise geometric reasoning (NutAssembly, Door). Critically, the diagnostic system correctly identifies failures in every case—the bottleneck is code synthesis, not failure detection. We also find

that human feedback during code iteration does not improve outcomes; the effective intervention point is phase design, where human strategy expertise has the highest leverage.

These findings support a phase-design-first architecture: humans define the strategy, domain constraints encode geometric knowledge, and the agent handles the implementation.

Future investigation. Our results raise a deeper question: is the failure on geometrically complex tasks a fundamental limitation of current LLM architectures, or can it be overcome with better prompting, fine-tuning, or tool-augmented generation? We plan to test this through controlled ablations: (1) providing geometric formulas in the prompt vs. requiring the LLM to derive them; (2) comparing across model families (GPT-4o, Claude, Qwen) to determine if failures are model-specific or class-wide; (3) evaluating constrained generation approaches where the LLM fills parameters in pre-built templates rather than generating full policies.

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